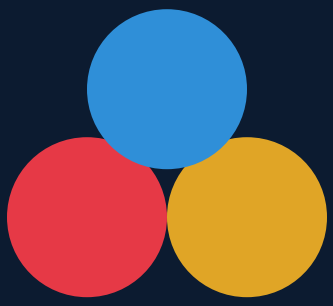


THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine · wake the block · don't become it

A cooperative game for 2–5 players · ages 12+ · 45–60 minutes

PRINT & PLAY KIT · rules v3

IN THIS KIT

How to make the decoder lens + printer test
Rulebook and quick reference
Game board
5 player boards
75 Deal cards (60 real traps, 15 honest deals) + backs
5 Roles · 4 Owners · 5 Scenarios · 12 Machine Patterns
Facilitator answer key
Playtest log

Part of the Individual Democracy / Civic Armor universe.

Before you cut: the decoder lens

What you need

A color printer, plain paper or light cardstock, scissors, about 40 small tokens (coins, beans, beads), and a sheet of RED transparent film — red acetate, a red lighting gel, red cellophane, or even a red candy wrapper. Two layers of thin cellophane work better than one.

How the trick works

Each hidden layer is printed in cyan, buried under dense red decoy letters. To the naked eye it's a red blur. Through the red lens the red washes out to the color of the paper and the cyan turns dark, so the second number appears.

Print settings

Print at 100% / 'Actual size' (not 'fit to page') in COLOR on the best quality setting. Card sheets are 2.5 × 3.5 in poker size, so they fit standard sleeves. Sleeving each card in front of an old playing card keeps cards opaque and shuffleable. Cut on the solid crop marks. Card backs are optional (print them on the reverse of any card sheet), but the Owner backs matter: glue or sleeve one onto each Owner card so the Owner stays hidden.

Test your printer first

Print this page and look at the three strips below through your lens. You should read each line clearly through the lens and NOT read it without one. If you can read the hidden line without the lens, use cardstock, a darker red film, or double up the film.

- 
- 
- 

The honor rule

Every deal card has three hidden zones: red (Sight 1), amber (Sight 2) and blue (Sight 3). When you face a deal, hold the lens only over the zones your Sight in that district unlocks — no deeper. The table watches. The lever (or 'honest deal') is printed inside the red zone, so a blind player (Sight 0) sees only the pitch.

THE SECOND NUMBER — Rulebook (v3)

A cooperative game for 2–5 players, ages 12+, about 45–60 minutes.

Read the machine. Wake the block. Crack the Underworld. Don't become it.

What's in the box

- **75 Deal cards**, 15 per district (Lending, Housing, Labor, Health, Education): 12 real traps and 3 honest deals each.
- **5 Role cards**, **4 Owner cards** (one is shuffled face-down under the board), **5 Scenario cards**, **12 Pattern cards**.
- **The board:** five districts. Each has a Clarity track (0–3) and a Machine track (0–3).
- Player boards with Trust (0–5), Corruption (0–6) and Sight (0–3 per district) tracks.
- **A red decoder lens.** The deluxe edition adds amber and blue lenses.
- About 40 small tokens (coins, beans or beads) for the tracks.

Reading a Deal card

Part	What it is	You can read it at
Front	The pitch everyone sees	always
🔴 Red	The real **cost**	Sight 1 in that district
🟡 Amber	The **clock**: the deadline or your rights window	Sight 2
🔵 Blue	The **connection**: who's really behind it	Sight 3
Lever (inside the red zone)	Which layer holds the leverage to **beat** it, or "honest deal"	Sight 1

Read only what your Sight allows. Hold the lens over the zones your Sight in that district unlocks, and no deeper. On your honor, and with the table watching.

Seeing is not beating. Sight 1 tells you whether a deal is a trap or honest. To negotiate a trap down, you need Sight that reaches its **lever**: red (1), amber (2) or blue (3). Honest deals have no lever.

Setup

1. Pick a **Scenario** (start with The Audit or A Quiet Year) and apply it.
2. Shuffle the **Owner** cards and slide one face-down under the board. Don't look at it.
3. Each player takes a **Role**, 2 Trust, 0 Corruption, and Sight 0 everywhere (the Elder starts with Sight 1 everywhere).
4. Look up your player count on the table below:

Players	Actions per turn	Machine strikes per round	Overlord moves per round
2	3	1	2
3	3	2	3, or 4 on even rounds
4	2	1	2
5	2	2	3

A round

1. Block turns. Each player in turn takes their actions, choosing from these (repeats allowed):

Action	What it does
Study	+1 Sight in one district. +1 Legend.
Face a deal	Draw a card from a district, read what your Sight allows, then choose **TAKE / WALK / NEGOTIATE** (below).

Action	What it does
Teach	Give a teammate +1 Sight in a district where you read better than they do (never above your own Sight). Costs 1 Trust; free for the Translator. +2 Legend.
Commons	+2 Trust (max 5) and −1 Corruption.
Reach	Pull a Fallen player home: costs 2 Trust; they return with Corruption 4. +3 Legend.
Trace (Underworld open only)	Needs Sight 3 in a woken district. Place a blue thread there. +2 Legend.
Expose (once enough threads are traced)	You win.

2. Check. If total Clarity across the board is **9 or more**, the Underworld cracks open (see below).

3. The Machine moves.

- It **strikes** the unwoken district closest to waking: +1 Pressure. It makes as many strikes as the table says, **each on a different district**.
- It **muddies** the strongest unwoken district: −1 Clarity.
- Then the Scenario, the hidden Owner, and any Patterns act.

4. Check for loss. You lose if **2 districts are captured** (Pressure 3), if **everyone has Fallen**, or if **round 12 ends**. The clock is the Machine's best friend.

The spread rule

The Machine, the Overlord and the Fallen together may act on **each district at most once per round**. The Machine spreads; it doesn't snipe.

- Patterns are the system itself, so they tighten regardless.
- A **woken** district (Clarity 3) is safe from the Machine until the Underworld opens.

Facing a deal: TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE

	On an honest deal	On a trap
TAKE	Real help: +2 Trust, +1 Clarity, +1 Legend	**The shortcut.** If the district has Pressure, −2 Pressure now; otherwise +2 Clarity now. Either way you take +2 Corruption and 0 Legend.
WALK	You refused real help out of fear: −1 Trust	Safe. Nothing gained.
NEGOTIATE (costs 1 Trust)	You haggled away real help. The Trust is gone.	**Sight ≥ lever:** defused. −1 Pressure (−2 for the Organizer), +1 Clarity, +2 Legend. **Sight < lever:** you got played. +1 Pressure.

Blind (Sight 0), you see only the front. Most deals are traps, but walking away from honest help costs Trust. Learning to read is how you stop guessing.

The shortcut, and the Fall

TAKE on a trap really is the fastest way to save a district one strike from capture. That's what makes it a temptation and not a trap card with a skull on it. But at **Corruption 6 you Fall**:

- You stay at the table, and **the Machine moves through you**. On your turn you take Machine moves (Extract, Obscure, Tempt) instead of block actions.
- Your crew can **Reach** you back.
- If the Machine wins with you Fallen, you "won the board" and earned **0 Legend**. You don't win by becoming the thing you fight.

The Underworld: the final act

When total Clarity reaches 9, flip the Owner card. **It fights in the open:**

- The Machine gets **+1 strike** per round.

- Once per round it **covers its tracks**: −1 Clarity on a woken district that doesn't yet have a thread.

To win, trace **3 blue threads**. Each needs **Sight 3 (blue)** in a woken district. Then take the **Expose** action. The districts looked separate; down here they're one machine.

Owners (hidden from round 1, so deduce them)

- **The Algorithm:** relentless. +1 Machine strike every round.
- **The Lobbyist:** leans on your strongest unwoken district every round (+1 Pressure). On reveal, it knocks one woken district back to Clarity 1.
- **The Debt Buyer:** every TAKE on a trap costs +1 Corruption. Each round, collections calls: anyone carrying Corruption loses 1 Trust. The Fallen take double moves.
- **The Recruiter:** each round, a random player loses 1 Sight in a district they can read.

Scenarios (an easy-to-hard ladder)

The Audit (one grace round) → A Quiet Year → The Eviction Wave (Housing starts at Pressure 2) → The Closure (Education starts captured; reclaim it) → Payday Season (every 3rd round, an extra Lending hit).

Patterns

When every district in a combination is at Pressure 2 or more, flip that Pattern card (Redlining, the Medical-Debt Spiral, and the rest). Read its explainer aloud.

- Each round, the largest active Pattern **tightens** (+1 Pressure on its weakest member).
- Pull any one of its districts back below Pressure 2 and the Pattern breaks.

Roles

Role	Gift
Translator	Teaches for free (still needs to read the district better than the learner).
Student	Gains double Sight when taught.
Elder	Starts with Sight 1 everywhere. Once per game, Teach the History: a district wakes instantly.
Veteran	Shields two Machine strikes per game.
Organizer	A successful NEGOTIATE drops Pressure by 2.

Overlord mode (optional, 1 vs. many)

One player is the Machine. There is no hidden Owner and no automatic Machine phase. Each round the Overlord takes the moves on the setup table (Extract +1 Pressure, Obscure −1 Clarity, Tempt −1 Trust), obeying the spread rule. After the Underworld opens, the Overlord may Obscure one woken, untraced district per round. Everything else is the same.

Scoring

Win or lose, the most **Legendary** player is the one who lifted the most people. Legend comes only from studying, teaching, defusing, reaching and tracing, never from taking.

> How high did you climb before you turned into the thing you were fighting?

Quick reference

Your turn	Take your actions (2–3, see setup table): Study · Face a deal · Teach · Commons · Reach · Trace · Expose.
Facing a deal	Draw from a district. Lens over the zones your Sight unlocks. Then TAKE / WALK / NEGOTIATE.
Honest deal	TAKE: +2 Trust, +1 Clarity, +1 Legend. WALK: −1 Trust. NEGOTIATE: the Trust is wasted.
Trap	TAKE: −2 Pressure now (or +2 Clarity if no Pressure), +2 Corruption. WALK: safe. NEGOTIATE (1 Trust): Sight ≥ lever → −1 Pressure (Organizer −2), +1 Clarity, +2 Legend; else +1 Pressure.
After all turns	Total Clarity ≥ 9 → the Underworld cracks open: flip the Owner.
Machine phase	Strikes (setup table), each on a different unwoken district, closest to waking first. Muddy the strongest unwoken district (−1 Clarity). Scenario, Owner, Patterns.
Owner in the open	+1 strike; once per round −1 Clarity on a woken district without a thread.
Lose	2 districts captured · everyone Fallen · round 12 ends.
Win	3 threads traced (Sight 3 in woken districts) → Expose.
Fallen	On your turn the Machine moves through you (Extract · Obscure · Tempt). Your crew can Reach you.

Setup by player count

Players	Actions per turn	Machine strikes	Overlord moves
2	3	1	2
3	3	2	3, or 4 on even rounds
4	2	1	2
5	2	2	3

THE SECOND NUMBER

the block · five districts, one machine

ROUND 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12

end of round 12 = the Machine wins

LENDING

CLARITY 3 = AWAKE

0 1 2 **3**

MACHINE 3 = CAPTURED

0 1 2 **3**

2+ = gripped (counts for Patterns)

Lending deal pile

THREAD

Sight 3 + awake → trace

HOUSING

CLARITY 3 = AWAKE

0 1 2 **3**

MACHINE 3 = CAPTURED

0 1 2 **3**

2+ = gripped (counts for Patterns)

Housing deal pile

THREAD

Sight 3 + awake → trace

LABOR

CLARITY 3 = AWAKE

0 1 2 **3**

MACHINE 3 = CAPTURED

0 1 2 **3**

2+ = gripped (counts for Patterns)

Labor deal pile

THREAD

Sight 3 + awake → trace

HEALTH

CLARITY 3 = AWAKE

0 1 2 **3**

MACHINE 3 = CAPTURED

0 1 2 **3**

2+ = gripped (counts for Patterns)

Health deal pile

THREAD

Sight 3 + awake → trace

EDUCATION

CLARITY 3 = AWAKE

0 1 2 **3**

MACHINE 3 = CAPTURED

0 1 2 **3**

2+ = gripped (counts for Patterns)

Education deal pile

THREAD

Sight 3 + awake → trace

THE UNDERWORLD

Total Clarity across all five districts. At 9 it cracks open: flip the Owner, it fights in the open (+1 strike, one cover-up per round). Trace 3 threads, then EXPOSE to win.

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 **9** 10 11 12 13 14 15

▲ 9: CRACKS OPEN

The spread rule: the Machine, the Overlord and the Fallen act on each district at most once per round.
Lose: 2 districts captured · everyone Falls · round 12 ends.

OWNER
face-down

ACTIVE PATTERNS
read them aloud

THE TRANSLATOR

Teaches for free (no Trust cost). Still has to read a district to teach it. The bridge — spreads the Sight fastest.

TRUST start 2 · spend on Negotiate, Teach, Reach

0	1	2	3	4	5

max 5

CORRUPTION TAKE on a trap +2 · Commons −1

0	1	2	3	4	5	6

6 = YOU FALL

SIGHT read only the zones you've unlocked

LENDING	0	1	2	3
HOUSING	0	1	2	3
LABOR	0	1	2	3
HEALTH	0	1	2	3
EDUCATION	0	1	2	3

ACTIONS

Study	+1 Sight in a district. +1 Legend.
Face a deal	Read what your Sight allows → TAKE / WALK / NEGOTIATE.
Teach	+1 Sight to a teammate where you read better. 1 Trust (Translator: free). +2 Legend.
Commons	+2 Trust, −1 Corruption.
Reach	2 Trust: a Fallen friend comes home at Corruption 4. +3 Legend.
Trace	Underworld open, Sight 3, district awake → place a thread. +2 Legend.
Expose	3 threads traced → the block wins.

LEGEND: _____

THE STUDENT

Gains DOUBLE Sight when taught. The hungry one.

TRUST start 2 · spend on Negotiate, Teach, Reach

0	1	2	3	4	5

max 5

CORRUPTION TAKE on a trap +2 · Commons −1

0	1	2	3	4	5	6

6 = YOU FALL

SIGHT read only the zones you've unlocked

LENDING	0	1	2	3
HOUSING	0	1	2	3
LABOR	0	1	2	3
HEALTH	0	1	2	3
EDUCATION	0	1	2	3

ACTIONS

Study	+1 Sight in a district. +1 Legend.
Face a deal	Read what your Sight allows → TAKE / WALK / NEGOTIATE.
Teach	+1 Sight to a teammate where you read better. 1 Trust (Translator: free). +2 Legend.
Commons	+2 Trust, −1 Corruption.
Reach	2 Trust: a Fallen friend comes home at Corruption 4. +3 Legend.
Trace	Underworld open, Sight 3, district awake → place a thread. +2 Legend.
Expose	3 threads traced → the block wins.

LEGEND: _____

THE ELDER

Starts with Sight 1 everywhere; once per game, 'Teach the History' wakes a whole district instantly.

TRUST start 2 · Elder starts Sight 1 everywhere · spend on Negotiate, Teach, Reach

0	1	2	3	4	5

max 5

CORRUPTION TAKE on a trap +2 · Commons −1

0	1	2	3	4	5	6

6 = YOU FALL

SIGHT read only the zones you've unlocked

LENDING	0	1	2	3
HOUSING	0	1	2	3
LABOR	0	1	2	3
HEALTH	0	1	2	3
EDUCATION	0	1	2	3

ACTIONS

Study	+1 Sight in a district. +1 Legend.
Face a deal	Read what your Sight allows → TAKE / WALK / NEGOTIATE.
Teach	+1 Sight to a teammate where you read better. 1 Trust (Translator: free). +2 Legend.
Commons	+2 Trust, −1 Corruption.
Reach	2 Trust: a Fallen friend comes home at Corruption 4. +3 Legend.
Trace	Underworld open, Sight 3, district awake → place a thread. +2 Legend.
Expose	3 threads traced → the block wins.

LEGEND: _____

THE VETERAN

Shields the block from two Machine hits per game. Came home to protect it.

TRUST start 2 · spend on Negotiate, Teach, Reach

0	1	2	3	4	5

max 5

CORRUPTION TAKE on a trap +2 · Commons −1

0	1	2	3	4	5	6

6 = YOU FALL

SIGHT read only the zones you've unlocked

LENDING	0	1	2	3
HOUSING	0	1	2	3
LABOR	0	1	2	3
HEALTH	0	1	2	3
EDUCATION	0	1	2	3

ACTIONS

Study	+1 Sight in a district. +1 Legend.
Face a deal	Read what your Sight allows → TAKE / WALK / NEGOTIATE.
Teach	+1 Sight to a teammate where you read better. 1 Trust (Translator: free). +2 Legend.
Commons	+2 Trust, −1 Corruption.
Reach	2 Trust: a Fallen friend comes home at Corruption 4. +3 Legend.
Trace	Underworld open, Sight 3, district awake → place a thread. +2 Legend.
Expose	3 threads traced → the block wins.

LEGEND: _____

THE ORGANIZER

A successful NEGOTIATE drops Pressure by 2, not 1 (collective action). Rallies the block.

TRUST start 2 · spend on Negotiate, Teach, Reach

0	1	2	3	4	5

max 5

CORRUPTION TAKE on a trap +2 · Commons −1

0	1	2	3	4	5	6

6 = YOU FALL

SIGHT read only the zones you've unlocked

LENDING	0	1	2	3
HOUSING	0	1	2	3
LABOR	0	1	2	3
HEALTH	0	1	2	3
EDUCATION	0	1	2	3

ACTIONS

Study	+1 Sight in a district. +1 Legend.
Face a deal	Read what your Sight allows → TAKE / WALK / NEGOTIATE.
Teach	+1 Sight to a teammate where you read better. 1 Trust (Translator: free). +2 Legend.
Commons	+2 Trust, −1 Corruption.
Reach	2 Trust: a Fallen friend comes home at Corruption 4. +3 Legend.
Trace	Underworld open, Sight 3, district awake → place a thread. +2 Legend.
Expose	3 threads traced → the block wins.

LEGEND: _____

(Print an extra copy of any board for a 6th seat or a spare.)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-01

WHAT YOU SEE

Quick Cash: $375 today. One flat fee — $56.25.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-02

WHAT YOU SEE

Title Loan: borrow $1,000 on your car title, keep driving.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-03

WHAT YOU SEE

Pawn: cash now for your item, buy it back anytime.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-04

WHAT YOU SEE

Buy Now, Pay Later: 4 easy payments, 0% interest!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-05

WHAT YOU SEE

Overdraft Protection: we'll cover your card if you're short.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-06

WHAT YOU SEE

Cash Advance App: get $100 early. No interest — just tip!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-07

WHAT YOU SEE

Refund Advance: your tax refund NOW, don't wait weeks.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-08

WHAT YOU SEE

Online Installment Loan: need $2,000? Easy approval.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-09

WHAT YOU SEE

Credit Builder: build your credit — guaranteed approval!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

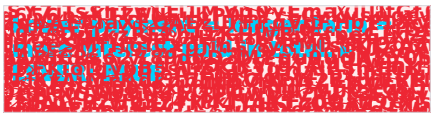
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-10

WHAT YOU SEE

Debt Consolidation: one low monthly payment, be debt-free!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



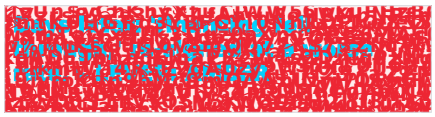
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-11

WHAT YOU SEE

Drive It Home Today — financing approved!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-12

WHAT YOU SEE

Check Cashing: cash your check instantly, no bank needed.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-13

WHAT YOU SEE

Credit-union personal loan: fixed low rate.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



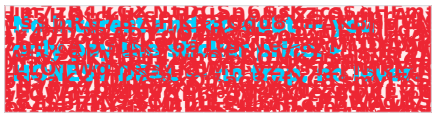
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-14

WHAT YOU SEE

Layaway: pay it off first, then take it home.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LENDING DEAL · LEN-15

WHAT YOU SEE

Free tax prep (VITA) + your refund by direct deposit.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-01

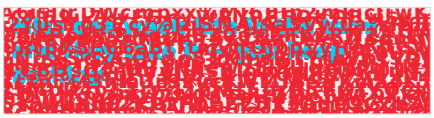
WHAT YOU SEE

Rent-to-Own: $25/week and the couch is yours!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-02

WHAT YOU SEE

No-Credit-Check Lease: bad credit? Move in today.

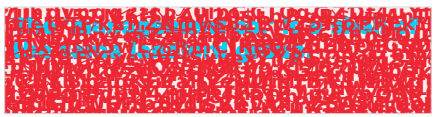
- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-03

WHAT YOU SEE

Own Your Home — no bank, no mortgage! (Contract-for-Deed)

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-04

WHAT YOU SEE

Rent is only $950!

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-05

WHAT YOU SEE

Just first month + deposit to move in.

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



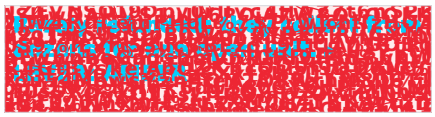
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-06

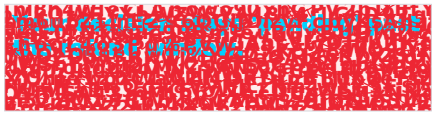
WHAT YOU SEE

$50 to apply — refundable if you're not approved!

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-07

WHAT YOU SEE

Renters insurance included for your protection.

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-08

WHAT YOU SEE

Welcome! Great intro rent.

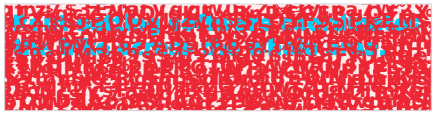
SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-09

WHAT YOU SEE

Low payment to get you in the door! (ARM mortgage)

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-10

WHAT YOU SEE

All utilities included — simple!

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-11

WHAT YOU SEE

Standard lease, just sign here.

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



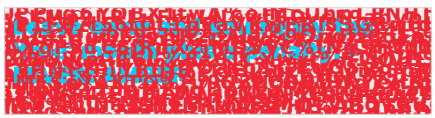
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING DEAL · HOU-12

WHAT YOU SEE

First month FREE!

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



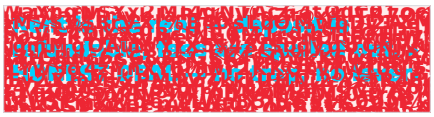
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING — DEAL · HOU-13

WHAT YOU SEE

A fair lease: normal deposit, clear terms.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING — DEAL · HOU-14

WHAT YOU SEE

Housing voucher (Section 8): inspected unit, capped rent.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HOUSING — DEAL · HOU-15

WHAT YOU SEE

Community land trust home: buy at a price you can afford.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR — DEAL · LAB-01

WHAT YOU SEE

Sign here to start Monday.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR — DEAL · LAB-02

WHAT YOU SEE

Standard new-hire paperwork. (Non-compete)

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR — DEAL · LAB-03

WHAT YOU SEE

You're an independent contractor — be your own boss!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR — DEAL · LAB-04

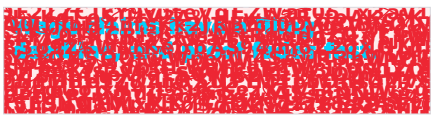
WHAT YOU SEE

Tips pooled and shared fairly, trust us.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR — DEAL · LAB-05

WHAT YOU SEE

Free training to start your career!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR — DEAL · LAB-06

WHAT YOU SEE

Come do a working interview!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR DEAL · LAB-07

WHAT YOU SEE

Flexible hours — we'll text you!

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR DEAL · LAB-08

WHAT YOU SEE

Get paid on a convenient card!

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR DEAL · LAB-09

WHAT YOU SEE

Shop at our store with your staff discount!

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR DEAL · LAB-10

WHAT YOU SEE

Set your own schedule, earn per job!

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR DEAL · LAB-11

WHAT YOU SEE

Congrats, you're salaried now — a manager!

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR DEAL · LAB-12

WHAT YOU SEE

Quick team meeting after your shift.

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



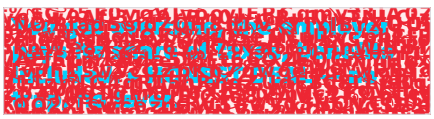
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR DEAL · LAB-13

WHAT YOU SEE

A real W-2 job: overtime, benefits, clear pay.

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



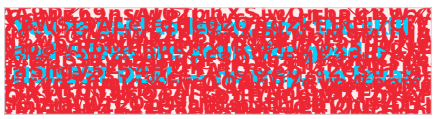
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR DEAL · LAB-14

WHAT YOU SEE

Union apprenticeship: paid training, raises you keep.

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

LABOR DEAL · LAB-15

WHAT YOU SEE

File a wage claim with the state labor office.

SIGHT 1 · THE COST



SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH DEAL · HEA-01

WHAT YOU SEE

In-network hospital — you're covered.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH DEAL · HEA-02

WHAT YOU SEE

Amount due: $8,400. FINAL.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH DEAL · HEA-03

WHAT YOU SEE

Medical card: 0% interest if paid in 12 months!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH DEAL · HEA-04

WHAT YOU SEE

Just a routine clinic visit.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH DEAL · HEA-05

WHAT YOU SEE

Please pay your balance today.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH DEAL · HEA-06

WHAT YOU SEE

Health coverage for just $99/mo! (Short-term plan)

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH DEAL · HEA-07

WHAT YOU SEE

We can set up a payment plan.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH DEAL · HEA-08

WHAT YOU SEE

Your copay is $60.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH DEAL · HEA-09

WHAT YOU SEE

We'll get you to the hospital. (Ambulance)

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH — DEAL · HEA-10

WHAT YOU SEE

Here's your total, pay at the desk.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH — DEAL · HEA-11

WHAT YOU SEE

Get the dental work done now — finance it!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH — DEAL · HEA-12

WHAT YOU SEE

We'll airlift you — don't worry about the cost.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



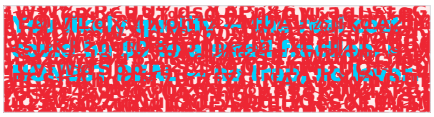
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH — DEAL · HEA-13

WHAT YOU SEE

Charity-care application at a nonprofit hospital.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH — DEAL · HEA-14

WHAT YOU SEE

Community clinic, sliding-scale fee.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

HEALTH — DEAL · HEA-15

WHAT YOU SEE

Marketplace plan with an income-based subsidy.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-01

WHAT YOU SEE

Enroll now — job placement guaranteed!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-02

WHAT YOU SEE

Approved! A private loan to cover your whole tuition.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-03

WHAT YOU SEE

Pay $0 now — just a % of your future income! (ISA)

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST



- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK



- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-04

WHAT YOU SEE

Just have a family member cosign.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-05

WHAT YOU SEE

Can't pay? Just defer — no worries!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-06

WHAT YOU SEE

6 weeks to a high-paying certification!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-07

WHAT YOU SEE

Start here, transfer anywhere later!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-08

WHAT YOU SEE

Tuition is all-inclusive!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-09

WHAT YOU SEE

A counselor will help you apply today!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-10

WHAT YOU SEE

We'll erase your student loans — for a fee!

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-11

WHAT YOU SEE

No cost until you're hired at $70k+! (Bootcamp ISA)

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION — DEAL · EDU-12

WHAT YOU SEE

Keep your license current — easy subscription.

- SIGHT 1 · THE COST
- SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK
- SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION

TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION DEAL · EDU-13

WHAT YOU SEE

Federal student aid (FAFSA): fixed rate, protections.

● **SIGHT 1 · THE COST**



● **SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK**



● **SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION**



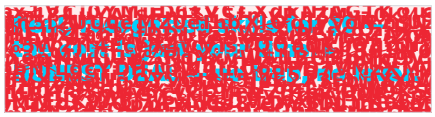
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION DEAL · EDU-14

WHAT YOU SEE

Public library / free certification program.

● **SIGHT 1 · THE COST**



● **SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK**



● **SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION**



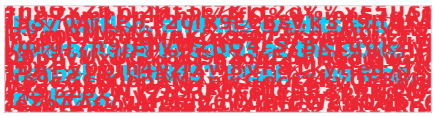
TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)

EDUCATION DEAL · EDU-15

WHAT YOU SEE

Community college with a guaranteed-transfer agreement.

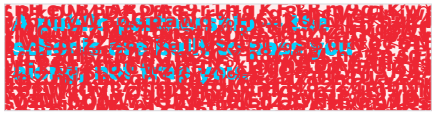
● **SIGHT 1 · THE COST**



● **SIGHT 2 · THE CLOCK**



● **SIGHT 3 · THE CONNECTION**



TAKE · WALK · NEGOTIATE (1 Trust, Sight ≥ lever)



THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine



THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine



THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine



THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine



THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine



THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine



THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine



THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine



THE SECOND NUMBER

read the machine

ROLE character

The Translator

Teaches for free (no Trust cost). Still has to read a district to teach it. The bridge — spreads the Sight fastest.

Start: 2 Trust · Sight 0.

ROLE character

The Student

Gains DOUBLE Sight when taught. The hungry one.

Start: 2 Trust · Sight 0.

ROLE character

The Elder

Starts with Sight 1 everywhere; once per game, 'Teach the History' wakes a whole district instantly.

Start: 2 Trust · Sight 1 in every district.

ROLE character

The Veteran

Shields the block from two Machine hits per game. Came home to protect it.

Start: 2 Trust · Sight 0.

ROLE character

The Organizer

A successful NEGOTIATE drops Pressure by 2, not 1 (collective action). Rallies the block.

Start: 2 Trust · Sight 0.

THE OWNER hidden

The Algorithm

Relentless. The Machine strikes one extra time every round.

Revealed when total Clarity reaches 9. Until then, watch the board and deduce it.

THE OWNER hidden

The Lobbyist

Each round it leans on your strongest unfinished district (+1 Pressure). On reveal it knocks one woken district back to Clarity 1.

Revealed when total Clarity reaches 9. Until then, watch the board and deduce it.

THE OWNER hidden

The Debt Buyer

Every TAKE on a trap costs +1 extra Corruption. Each round, collections calls: anyone carrying Corruption loses 1 Trust. The Fallen strike twice as hard.

Revealed when total Clarity reaches 9. Until then, watch the board and deduce it.

THE OWNER hidden

The Recruiter

Each round it peels someone away: a random player loses 1 Sight in a district they can read.

Revealed when total Clarity reaches 9. Until then, watch the board and deduce it.

SCENARIO setup

The Eviction Wave

Housing starts under siege (2 pressure). Hold the line.

SCENARIO setup

Payday Season

Every third round is payday: Lending takes an extra hit. The hardest rung.

SCENARIO setup

The Closure

A school starts captured (3 Pressure). Reclaim it — fast.

SCENARIO setup

The Audit

The Machine is distracted — the block gets a one-round head start.

SCENARIO setup

A Quiet Year

No special pressure. Learn the ropes.

MACHINE PATTERN HOU + LEN

Redlining

Credit and housing denied by geography — your address decides what money costs you.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN HEA + LEN

The Medical-Debt Spiral

One illness becomes a debt becomes ruined credit. A leading cause of bankruptcy in America.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN EDU + LEN

The Debt Diploma

The school and the loan servicer are one hand. They sold you the loan, not the future.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN LAB + LEN

Wage Capture

Wages kept just low enough that you need the loan to live — so you work to pay the lender.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN HOU + LAB

No Address, No Job

Lose the job, lose the home; no address, no hire. The two feed each other into a spiral.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN HOU + EDU

Zip-Code Destiny

School funding tied to property values — the block the Machine drained gets the worst schools.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN HEA + LAB

The Expendable Worker

Misclassified so there's no workers' comp and no benefits — get hurt and you're discarded.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN EDU + LAB

The Pipeline To Nowhere

Trained and charged for jobs that don't exist. School-to-dead-end by design.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN HOU + LEN + LAB

The Extraction Zone

No jobs, predatory credit, housing that builds no wealth. Concentrated poverty, engineered.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN HEA + HOU + LEN

The Wipeout

Medical event → debt → lose the house. A whole family erased in one bad year.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN EDU + LEN + LAB

The Sold Future

Debt diploma + no jobs + more loans. Paying forever for a door that was never open.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.

MACHINE PATTERN HOU + LEN + LAB + HEA + EDU

The Captured City

All five in the grip — generational poverty, by design. The whole machine, out in the open.

Forms when every district listed is at Pressure 2+. Tightens each round. Break it by pulling one district below 2.



THE OWNER

one machine · one hand



THE OWNER

one machine · one hand



THE OWNER

one machine · one hand



THE OWNER

one machine · one hand



THE OWNER

one machine · one hand



THE OWNER

one machine · one hand



THE OWNER

one machine · one hand



THE OWNER

one machine · one hand



THE OWNER

one machine · one hand

Facilitator answer key

Every deal, in plain text. For teachers and facilitators, and to settle a hard-to-read card. Players: don't peek. Learning to read the card is the game.

LENDING

ID	What you see	Lever	Red — the cost	Amber — the clock	Blue — the connection
LEN-01	**Quick Cash: $375 today. One flat fee — $56.25.**	**RED**	That fee is a 391% APR. The fee is the product, not a favor.	Due in full in 14 days. Can't pay? You 'reroll' and owe $56 again.	The storefront and the debt buyer that hounds you later share one owner.
LEN-02	**Title Loan: borrow $1,000 on your car title, keep driving.**	**AMBER**	~300% APR, and the loan is a fraction of the car's real value.	One missed payment = repossession, often with no grace period.	The lender holds a stake in the repo lot that resells your car.
LEN-03	**Pawn: cash now for your item, buy it back anytime.**	**AMBER**	Effective APR 120–240%; most items are never redeemed.	The redemption window is short — miss it and it's sold.	Resale profit flows to the same chain that wrote the loan.
LEN-04	**Buy Now, Pay Later: 4 easy payments, 0% interest!**	**AMBER**	Late fees pile on, and it stacks across apps till you lose track.	Autopay hits whether the money's there or not → overdraft.	The BNPL firm sells your payment data and routes late fees up.
LEN-05	**Overdraft Protection: we'll cover your card if you're short.**	**RED**	Up to ~$35 per swipe — a $4 coffee can cost ~$39 (many banks now $0–$15).	Charges reordered largest-first to trigger the most fees.	Overdraft fees are a top profit line for the bank behind it.
LEN-06	**Cash Advance App: get $100 early. No interest — just tip!**	**BLUE**	A $14 'tip' + fee on $100 for a week ≈ 300%+ APR.	Auto-debits on payday; bad timing sets off an overdraft cascade.	The 'tip' dodges lending law; the app sells your bank data.
LEN-07	**Refund Advance: your tax refund NOW, don't wait weeks.**	**RED**	Fees + interest eat a refund you'd get free in a few days.	Due when the IRS pays — any delay becomes your problem.	The preparer, the bank, and the loan are one packaged product.
LEN-08	**Online Installment Loan: need $2,000? Easy approval.**	**BLUE**	100%+ APR by renting an out-of-state bank to dodge your state's cap.	Balloon structure — early payments barely touch the principal.	A fintech fronts it; a far-off bank lends its charter for a cut.
LEN-09	**Credit Builder: build your credit — guaranteed approval!**	**RED**	You pay fees for a 'loan' you can't touch; it may not even report.	Cancel late and you eat months of fees for nothing.	The fees are the business; your 'credit building' is the bait.
LEN-10	**Debt Consolidation: one low monthly payment, be debt-free!**	**BLUE**	Lower payment = longer term = more interest paid in total.	Stop paying creditors as told and your credit craters first.	The 'nonprofit' is funded by fees from the lenders it deals with.
LEN-11	**Drive It Home Today — financing approved!**	**AMBER**	Days later: 'financing fell through,' re-signed at a worse rate.	They hold your trade-in and down payment hostage to force the redo.	The dealer and the finance arm split the markup on your rate.
LEN-12	**Check Cashing: cash your check instantly, no bank needed.**	**RED**	1–5% per check — hundreds a year to reach your own money.	Every payday, every time. It never stops.	The chain also sells the payday loans you'll 'need' next.
LEN-13	**Credit-union personal loan: fixed low rate.**	**HONEST**	A fair APR — the rate is the whole story, no hidden second number.	No prepayment penalty; pay it early and save.	Member-owned nonprofit; the profit returns to members like you.
LEN-14	**Layaway: pay it off first, then take it home.**	**HONEST**	No interest and no debt — you only pay the sticker price.	Miss payments and you just get your money back, minus a small fee.	Old-school model with nobody profiting off your debt.
LEN-15	**Free tax prep (VITA) + your refund by direct deposit.**	**HONEST**	$0 to file, and the full refund is yours — no advance fee.	E-file with direct deposit and it usually lands in about 3 weeks.	An IRS-backed volunteer program; nobody earns a cut of your refund.

HOUSING

ID	What you see	Lever	Red — the cost	Amber — the clock	Blue — the connection
HOU-01	**Rent-to-Own: $25/week and the couch is yours!**	**RED**	Total paid = 2–4x the retail price.	Miss one week late in the term and they take it — you keep nothing.	The store and the lease company are one holding company.
HOU-02	**No-Credit-Check Lease: bad credit? Move in today.**	**AMBER**	Huge deposit + junk fees; rent set above market for 'risk'.	A 60-day move-out notice is buried inside — miss it, it auto-renews.	The 'management co.' is a shell of the same landlord group.
HOU-03	**Own Your Home — no bank, no mortgage! (Contract-for-Deed)**	**BLUE**	You build no equity; miss a payment late and lose it all.	One default — even near the end — forfeits everything you paid.	The seller reclaims and resells the same house again and again.

ID	What you see	Lever	Red — the cost	Amber — the clock	Blue — the connection
HOU-04	**Rent is only $950!**	**RED**	'Technology fee,' 'convenience fee,' 'valet trash' add $100+/mo.	Fees climb at renewal while the base rent stays 'the same'.	A third-party fee processor splits the take with the landlord.
HOU-05	**Just first month + deposit to move in.**	**AMBER**	Move-out charges get invented to keep your whole deposit.	The dispute window is tight — miss it and it's gone.	A 'turnover' vendor profits from every withheld deposit.
HOU-06	**$50 to apply — refundable if you're not approved!**	**AMBER**	Rarely refunded; they collect from dozens for one open unit.	Your decision stays 'pending' past the refund window.	The screening company and the landlord share the fee pool.
HOU-07	**Renters insurance included for your protection.**	**BLUE**	A marked-up policy that mostly protects the landlord, not you.	Auto-added monthly; opting out is hidden and time-boxed.	The landlord earns a commission on every policy.
HOU-08	**Welcome! Great intro rent.**	**BLUE**	Renewal jumps 15–30%; moving costs trap you into paying it.	Your notice to leave is due before you even learn the new rate.	Rent-setting software coordinates the hike across the whole area.
HOU-09	**Low payment to get you in the door! (ARM mortgage)**	**RED**	The teaser rate resets far higher — your payment can double.	The reset date was set on day one; the clock always ran.	The loan is sold upstream; the servicer profits when you struggle.
HOU-10	**All utilities included — simple!**	**RED**	A flat 'utility' charge set far above your real usage.	The rate adjusts up yearly with no itemized proof.	A submetering vendor splits the overcharge with ownership.
HOU-11	**Standard lease, just sign here.**	**RED**	Waives your notice and auto-adds 'attorney fees' on any late rent.	Late by a day → filing starts and fees attach immediately.	A high-volume eviction law firm is paid per filing by the group.
HOU-12	**First month FREE!**	**AMBER**	Leave early and you repay the 'free' month plus a penalty.	The clawback triggers on any break before month 13.	Concessions are booked as debt you owe the property fund.
HOU-13	**A fair lease: normal deposit, clear terms.**	**HONEST**	Rent is the rent — deposit is refundable, fees are spelled out.	Standard notice period, plainly stated. No buried clause.	A small local landlord, not a shell of a national fund.
HOU-14	**Housing voucher (Section 8): inspected unit, capped rent.**	**HONEST**	Your share of rent is capped to your income — the real cost is low.	Annual recertification, clearly scheduled.	A public program built to keep you housed, not to extract.
HOU-15	**Community land trust home: buy at a price you can afford.**	**HONEST**	A real mortgage you can carry; you build equity as you pay.	Resale is capped, and that's spelled out on day one.	The trust holds the land so the next family can afford it too.

LABOR

ID	What you see	Lever	Red — the cost	Amber — the clock	Blue — the connection
LAB-01	**Sign here to start Monday.**	**AMBER**	You waive your right to sue or join a class action.	The 30-day opt-out is buried on page 9 — the clock starts now.	The arbitration firm is chosen and paid by the employer.
LAB-02	**Standard new-hire paperwork. (Non-compete)**	**BLUE**	Can block you from your whole field for a year+ (enforceability varies by state).	Signed at hire; enforced exactly when you try to leave.	Used to hold wages down across an entire local industry.
LAB-03	**You're an independent contractor — be your own boss!**	**RED**	No overtime, no benefits; you pay both halves of payroll tax.	Back-pay and benefit claims expire if you don't file in time.	The staffing agency pockets what your protections would've cost.
LAB-04	**Tips pooled and shared fairly, trust us.**	**RED**	Managers skim the pool; off-clock work goes unpaid.	Wage claims have a filing deadline, and proof fades fast.	Skimmed wages become the owner's margin.
LAB-05	**Free training to start your career!**	**AMBER**	Quit within 2 years and owe thousands for that 'training'.	The debt clock starts day one and follows you out the door.	The 'debt' is sold to a collector the moment you leave.
LAB-06	**Come do a working interview!**	**RED**	Hours of real labor with no pay — and often no job after.	'We'll decide later' — payday never comes.	Serial trial shifts quietly staff the floor for free.
LAB-07	**Flexible hours — we'll text you!**	**AMBER**	You hold the day open, get called off, and earn nothing.	Hours cut just below the benefits threshold on purpose.	Scheduling software optimizes you to part-time, no benefits.
LAB-08	**Get paid on a convenient card!**	**RED**	Fees to check your balance, to withdraw, even to stay active.	Inactivity fees drain it if you don't cash out fast.	The card issuer and employer split the fee revenue.

ID	What you see	Lever	Red — the cost	Amber — the clock	Blue — the connection
LAB-09	**Shop at our store with your staff discount!**	**AMBER**	Wages steered back to the employer at marked-up prices.	Advances against pay keep you one cycle behind, always.	The modern company town — you owe your soul to the store.
LAB-10	**Set your own schedule, earn per job!**	**BLUE**	Pay per task drops as you come to rely on it; costs are all yours.	Incentives expire; the 'bonus' always moves out of reach.	The platform tunes your pay to the lowest you'll still accept.
LAB-11	**Congrats, you're salaried now — a manager!**	**RED**	A 'manager' title used to dodge overtime on 60-hour weeks.	Your duties never match the title; claims expire quietly.	Your unpaid overtime is pure profit upstream.
LAB-12	**Quick team meeting after your shift.**	**BLUE**	Off-clock captive meetings, with anti-organizing pressure.	Attendance is tracked; refusing is quietly punished.	Union-avoidance consultants are paid to keep you quiet.
LAB-13	**A real W-2 job: overtime, benefits, clear pay.**	**HONEST**	You get overtime, the employer pays its share of taxes, benefits included.	Pay schedule and raises are written and predictable.	Classified correctly — your protections are intact.
LAB-14	**Union apprenticeship: paid training, raises you keep.**	**HONEST**	You're paid to learn, and the skill and raises are yours for good.	A clear schedule of raises as you hit milestones.	Collective bargaining puts the leverage on your side.
LAB-15	**File a wage claim with the state labor office.**	**HONEST**	Free to file — and it's illegal for the boss to retaliate.	The deadline is long, but file soon while the records are fresh.	The public enforcer works for you, not the employer.

HEALTH

ID	What you see	Lever	Red — the cost	Amber — the clock	Blue — the connection
HEA-01	**In-network hospital — you're covered.**	**AMBER**	An out-of-network doctor inside it bills you the gap.	Since 2022 the No Surprises Act bans this for ER/emergency care — dispute it.	Staffing firms place out-of-network docs in in-network ERs on purpose.
HEA-02	**Amount due: $8,400. FINAL.**	**RED**	It's an opening offer — cash and charity rates are far lower.	Negotiate before it hits collections or the number hardens.	Hospital, biller, and collector are one revenue chain.
HEA-03	**Medical card: 0% interest if paid in 12 months!**	**AMBER**	Deferred interest — miss the date and they backdate ALL of it.	The 0% clock ends quietly on a date you'll forget.	The clinic earns a cut for every patient it signs up.
HEA-04	**Just a routine clinic visit.**	**BLUE**	A separate 'facility fee' for the room — often more than the visit.	It shows up weeks later as a second, surprise bill.	Hospitals buy up clinics just to attach facility fees.
HEA-05	**Please pay your balance today.**	**RED**	You likely qualify for charity care they never mentioned.	Eligibility windows close while they push you to pay.	Nonprofits owe charity care but profit by collecting instead.
HEA-06	**Health coverage for just $99/mo! (Short-term plan)**	**RED**	Denies pre-existing conditions; caps leave you exposed.	Claims denied after care, and appeal windows are short.	The broker earns a fat commission on junk plans.
HEA-07	**We can set up a payment plan.**	**AMBER**	The plan reports to credit and can lead to liens or garnishment.	Statute-of-limitations tricks restart the debt clock.	The debt is sold for pennies; the collector profits on the spread.
HEA-08	**Your copay is $60.**	**RED**	The cash price can be lower than your insured copay.	'Gag clauses' once barred pharmacists from telling you.	Pharmacy middlemen pocket the spread between list and real price.
HEA-09	**We'll get you to the hospital. (Ambulance)**	**BLUE**	Ground ambulances are often out-of-network — and still exempt from the No Surprises Act.	The bill arrives later; you had no way to choose in the moment.	Private-equity-owned ambulance firms balance-bill on purpose.
HEA-10	**Here's your total, pay at the desk.**	**AMBER**	Errors and duplicate charges hide in the itemization you didn't see.	Request the itemized bill fast — before it's marked 'final'.	Upcoding inflates the bill; the chain keeps the overcharge.
HEA-11	**Get the dental work done now — finance it!**	**RED**	In-office financing at high deferred interest.	The promo ends mid-treatment and the rate jumps.	The provider is paid upfront; you're left owing the lender.
HEA-12	**We'll airlift you — don't worry about the cost.**	**BLUE**	Air-ambulance bills run $30k–$50k — but the No Surprises Act (2022) now shields most of it.	You still can't consent to the price mid-emergency, so know your protection.	PE-owned air fleets long relied on balance billing as the business model.
HEA-13	**Charity-care application at a nonprofit hospital.**	**HONEST**	You likely qualify — the real cost could be $0 to a small fraction.	Apply within the window and the balance can be wiped.	Nonprofit hospitals are required to offer this; it's your right.

ID	What you see	Lever	Red — the cost	Amber — the clock	Blue — the connection
HEA-14	**Community clinic, sliding-scale fee.**	**HONEST**	The price is matched to your income — no surprise markup.	Set your fee up front; no bill ambush later.	Federally supported care designed to reach everyone.
HEA-15	**Marketplace plan with an income-based subsidy.**	**HONEST**	Covers pre-existing conditions; the subsidy cuts the premium.	Sign up in open enrollment, or within 60 days of a life change.	A public program with real rules; the plan can't deny you for being sick.

EDUCATION

ID	What you see	Lever	Red — the cost	Amber — the clock	Blue — the connection
EDU-01	**Enroll now — job placement guaranteed!**	**AMBER**	Low grad rates; 'placement' counts any job, not the career.	The enrollment deadline pushes you past the refund date.	The school and the loan servicer are one owner.
EDU-02	**Approved! A private loan to cover your whole tuition.**	**RED**	Variable rate, fewer protections than federal — take federal first.	The rate resets on a schedule you don't control.	The servicer profits the longer you stay in debt.
EDU-03	**Pay $0 now — just a % of your future income! (ISA)**	**AMBER**	Can cost far more than a normal loan if you actually succeed.	The percentage and term lock in before you know your salary.	Investors bought a slice of your future paycheck.
EDU-04	**Just have a family member cosign.**	**AMBER**	The cosigner is fully liable; default wrecks their credit too.	The 'release' option has conditions almost no one ever meets.	Binding family debt is a feature, not a bug, for the lender.
EDU-05	**Can't pay? Just defer — no worries!**	**RED**	Unpaid interest is added to principal; the debt grows while you wait.	Capitalization hits on a date buried in the terms.	A bigger balance means more servicer profit.
EDU-06	**6 weeks to a high-paying certification!**	**BLUE**	A credential employers don't recognize, with sky-high fees.	No refund once the first module 'starts'.	The 'accreditor' is paid by the schools it blesses.
EDU-07	**Start here, transfer anywhere later!**	**RED**	The credits don't transfer; you pay to retake them.	You find out only after you've enrolled and paid.	Non-transferable credits lock you into one paying school.
EDU-08	**Tuition is all-inclusive!**	**RED**	Mandatory 'lab,' 'tech,' and book fees stack up fast.	Fees are billed per term and rise each year.	A captive bookstore/vendor shares in the markup.
EDU-09	**A counselor will help you apply today!**	**BLUE**	'Counselors' are commissioned salespeople hitting enrollment quotas.	High pressure: 'enroll today or lose your spot.'	Recruiters are paid per signed enrollment, not per graduate.
EDU-10	**We'll erase your student loans — for a fee!**	**RED**	Charges you for free federal programs; can forfeit protections.	Pay upfront, then 'processing' drags past your real options.	A fee-mill resells your info to the next scam in line.
EDU-11	**No cost until you're hired at $70k+! (Bootcamp ISA)**	**BLUE**	Broad definitions of 'hired' trigger payments even on low pay.	The clock and salary floor are written to favor the school.	Financiers bundle and securitize cohorts of students like bonds.
EDU-12	**Keep your license current — easy subscription.**	**AMBER**	Auto-renews yearly at a higher rate for credits you're required to have.	The cancel window is tiny and lands right before renewal.	A captive provider holds a monopoly on the required credits.
EDU-13	**Federal student aid (FAFSA): fixed rate, protections.**	**HONEST**	Fixed rate, income-driven repayment, forgiveness options — take this first.	Clear, federal timelines; deferment won't quietly capitalize the same way.	Public aid built for you, not an investor's return.
EDU-14	**Public library / free certification program.**	**HONEST**	Real, recognized skills for $0 — the cost is just your time.	Go at your own pace; no refund deadline to beat.	A public good with nobody profiting off your enrollment.
EDU-15	**Community college with a guaranteed-transfer agreement.**	**HONEST**	Low tuition, and the credits are guaranteed to count at the state school.	Follow the transfer map from semester one.	A public partnership — the schools are built to pass you along, not trap you.

Playtest log

The hard 80% of a board game is playtesting. Fill in a row after every game, and ask the table the questions below. Then run `python3 balance_test.py` after any rule change.

Date	Players / roles	Scenario	Owner	Result	Round	Who Fell?	Most Legendary

Ask the table

- When did you first gasp at a second number? Which card?
- Did anyone TAKE a shortcut on purpose? Was it worth it?
- Was there a turn where you had nothing good to do?
- Did the game end too soon, too late, or about right?
- Name one real deal from your own life you'd now read differently.

How high did you climb before you turned into the thing you were fighting?